style of the Sadozais, which the Barakzais had abandoned. The old offices of state were reinstated and with them the elaborate uniforms which so amazed British observers: ‘The court officials should really be viewed in a body of some hundreds,’ wrote the artist James Rattray, ‘dressed in crimson jackets, and bearing on their heads their high fantastic caps of every conceivable semblance. Some are ornamented with huge ears like asses, or spikes like those of porcupines, while others take the form of goat and buffalo horns, and many are conical, spiral or bell-shaped. These caps are all more or less decorated with figures and devices, some bearing a spear head as an emblem of superior rank.’[21] In formal durbar, Shuja himself was dressed no less remarkably, with a long choga hanging loose over his shoulder, ornamented with jewels at the loops, while the corners of his doge-like hat were edged with velvet pendants. He would remain seated on his octagonal white marble throne while receiving petitioners, and would rise only to receive the most senior British officials. On these occasions he would lean on a long curvilinear antelope horn, ‘the expression on his face grave and careworn’.

As winter tightened its grip, the days grew colder and the low, heavy clouds filled with snow that would not fall, Shuja decided to award selected officers with a new medal of his own invention. This was the Order of the Durrani Empire, whose shape and physical form seems to have been modelled on that of the Freemason medal, the Guelphian Order, which Burnes had been awarded after his return from Bukhara.[22] These were given out as the first regiments began the long march back to India, before the first flurries of winter snow thickened into drifts and closed the higher passes. As George Lawrence, Macnaghten’s young Military Secretary, noticed: ‘The recipients were entirely composed of British officers of the force, as none of his own subjects were regarded as worthy of the honor.’[23]

By late November the first returning regiments had reached Simla, ‘and very flourishing they look’, wrote Emily Eden. ‘They cannot now make out that their sufferings have been all that the papers described. Rather than having undergone privations, they are all looking uncommonly fat. Indeed Captain Dawkins, of Lord Auckland’s bodyguard, has come back looking fatter than most Falstaffs.’[24]